IOWN

The Morning Brief

APRIL 21, 2026

Expiry Day

The two-week ceasefire expires today with no extension in sight as Trump calls renewal "highly unlikely," oil rebounds 4.5%, and the IEA declares the largest energy crisis in history.

S&P 500	BRENT CRUDE	GOLD	BITCOIN	FEAR & GREED
7,087 ↓0.20%	~$95 ↑4.35%	~$4,860 ↓0.86%	~$75,500 ↓1.6%	33 · Fear (improving)

SECTION 01

Markets

THE MARKET ABSORBED THE WEEKEND ESCALATION — BUT TODAY TESTS THAT RESILIENCE

Monday's session was among the mildest responses to a weekend escalation of the entire conflict. The S&P 500 slipped just 0.20%, the Dow was essentially flat (+0.02%), the Nasdaq dipped 0.32%, and the Russell 2000 actually led at +0.57%. UVXY rose only 1.70%—a fraction of the double-digit spikes that accompanied prior escalations. The market's message is clear: seven weeks of war have compressed the equity risk premium to the point where even a ship seizure and Hormuz re-closure produce a 20-basis-point drawdown rather than a 2% selloff. Oil, however, repriced meaningfully: WTI surged 4.55% and Brent gained 4.35%, recovering a portion of Friday's 7%+ crash. The divergence between equity resilience and oil repricing suggests the market is treating the ceasefire fraying as a commodity event rather than a systemic risk event. Today is the test: the ceasefire expires, Trump has called an extension "highly unlikely," and no Iranian delegation has departed for Islamabad.

STEEL AND SEMIS LED THE TAPE — STLD +4.51%, ADI +2.58%

The session's leadership came from two corners of the portfolio that benefit from distinct catalysts. STLD surged 4.51% to $209.35, driven by tariff-supported domestic steel pricing and elevated infrastructure demand that has persisted through the conflict. ADI gained 2.58%, NXPI added 2.46%, and QCOM rose 0.97%—the semiconductor sleeve continues its multi-week recovery as AI infrastructure demand remains the cleanest secular growth thesis regardless of the geopolitical backdrop. HUT led the portfolio at +5.46% as Bitcoin consolidated near $75,500 despite the broader crypto weakness (ETHA −4.13%). COIN added 2.57%. On the downside, CL fell 2.66% on margin pressure from energy costs, GFI declined 2.36% as gold gave back further, and CNX dropped 1.86%. Benchmarks reflected the rotation: IUSG slipped 0.42% while DVY edged higher (+0.14%), and IWS gained 0.42%—the mid-cap value sleeve holding up.

OIL BOUNCED 4.5% — THE HORMUZ RE-CLOSURE REVERSES FRIDAY'S PEACE CRASH

WTI rose 4.55% and Brent gained 4.35% on Monday, recovering roughly half of Friday's 7%+ decline. The catalyst was Iran's Saturday decision to halt all Hormuz traffic following the US Navy ship seizure, effectively reversing the partial opening that drove Friday's oil crash. VLO, which fell 7.48% on Friday, stabilized with energy XLE barely positive (+0.09%). CVX and OKE were also roughly flat. The energy sleeve is now oscillating with each headline rather than trending in either direction—a volatility regime that is fundamentally different from the one-directional premium

expansion of the conflict's first five weeks. The IEA has characterized the situation as the "biggest energy crisis in history," per Reuters—a label that reflects the cumulative supply disruption even as markets have partially adjusted.

S&P 500	7,087 · ↓0.20% · Held within 0.2% of ATH
OIL	WTI ↑4.55% · Brent ↑4.35% · Hormuz re-closed Saturday
STLD	$209.35 · ↑4.51% · Tariff + infrastructure tailwind
IEA	Declares "biggest energy crisis in history"
FEAR & GREED	33 · Continues improving from single-digit lows
CEASEFIRE	Expires today · Trump: extension "highly unlikely"

The market held within 0.2% of its all-time high on the day the ceasefire began to collapse. That is the signal. Seven weeks of war have taught the market that the conflict is a commodity shock, not a systemic crisis—and equity positioning has adjusted accordingly. Today's expiry will test whether that distinction holds. **Think Like an Owner.**

Geopolitics

CEASEFIRE EXPIRES TODAY — NO EXTENSION, NO TALKS, NO FRAMEWORK

The two-week ceasefire, mediated by Pakistan and announced April 8, expires today with no confirmed extension. Trump stated Monday that renewal is "highly unlikely," according to CNN. A US delegation was preparing to travel to Islamabad for a potential second round, but no Iranian delegation has departed, according to Al Jazeera. Iran's parliament speaker accused the US of "imposing a siege and violating the ceasefire." The core sticking points remain unchanged from the first round of talks on April 11: Iran's nuclear program and sovereign control of the Strait of Hormuz. The expiry does not necessarily mean an immediate resumption of active hostilities—the original five-day pause in late March also expired without formal extension yet hostilities did not immediately resume. However, the rhetoric from both sides is materially more hostile than during the prior expiry windows. CNBC characterized the situation as a "resumption of hostilities" risk, citing the ship seizure and Saturday's vessel attacks.

IEA: BIGGEST ENERGY CRISIS IN HISTORY — THE INSTITUTIONAL LABEL MATTERS

The International Energy Agency officially characterized the Iran conflict as having caused the "biggest energy crisis in history," per Reuters. The label places the current disruption above the 1973 Arab oil embargo and the 1990 Gulf War in terms of cumulative supply impact. Hormuz transit remains at a fraction of pre-war levels; Iran's Saturday decision to re-close the Strait following the ship seizure reversed the limited opening that had been established under the ceasefire. Scam messages offering ships "safe transit" through Hormuz have proliferated, prompting security firm warnings. India's March crude imports declined as Russian volumes hit record highs, underscoring the global supply chain rerouting triggered by the crisis. For IOWN's energy sleeve, the IEA's characterization validates the structural disruption thesis that has underpinned CVX, VLO, and OKE throughout the conflict.

CeasefireExpires today · No extension confirmed
TrumpExtension "highly unlikely" (CNN)
Islamabad TalksUS delegation preparing · No Iranian delegation departed
IEA"Biggest energy crisis in history" (Reuters)
IndiaMarch crude imports down · Russian volumes at record

SECTION 03

On Our Radar

1. March Retail Sales arrive at 8:30 AM ET — the consumer's war-era verdict. The control group is expected at +0.2% MoM, down from +0.5% prior. Retail sales have been resilient through the first month of elevated gasoline prices, but March data reflects the period when pump prices surged most sharply (gasoline +21.2% in March CPI). A miss below zero would signal that the energy shock is finally constraining consumer spending—a deterioration that would pressure discretionary holdings and complicate the recovery narrative. An in-line print would suggest the consumer remains intact despite the inflation overhang. ADP weekly employment data also arrives today. *Research Reveals Opportunities.*

2. The ceasefire expiry is today's binary event, but the market's prior-session behavior suggests limited downside even in a lapse. Monday's –0.20% reaction to the ship seizure and Hormuz re-closure was the mildest escalation response of the entire conflict. If hostilities formally resume, oil likely retests $100+ Brent and the energy sleeve reasserts, but equities may hold above 7,000 given the institutional repositioning visible in the F&G improvement from 8 to 33. If a de facto pause persists even without formal extension—which prior expiry windows have demonstrated is possible—the market continues consolidating at these levels. *Avoid Erosion.*

3. SYF reports Q1 today — the first IOWN financial to report this cycle. Synchrony Financial enters Q1 reporting with consensus around $2.22 per share. The big-bank cycle delivered strong trading and banking fee results; SYF's consumer credit-focused model provides a different read—specifically on credit card delinquencies, net charge-offs, and consumer payment behavior during the war-driven inflation surge. SYF gained 1.91% on the prior session. A beat would validate the dividend sleeve's consumer credit thesis. *Think Like an Owner.*

4. Fear & Greed at 33 reflects a regime change in market psychology. The improvement from single digits at the conflict's nadir to 33 represents the most sustained sentiment recovery since the war began. Goldman data showed $86 billion in hedge fund buying last week. The reading remains well below neutral (50), suggesting further room for institutional catch-up if the ceasefire extends or the diplomatic track produces progress. If the ceasefire lapses and oil spikes, the index may retrace toward the low-20s but is unlikely to return to single digits given the structural repositioning already underway. **Simplicity Over Complexity.**

5. STLD +4.51% signals that the industrial sleeve has a tariff-driven floor. Steel Dynamics reported Q1 earnings last week ($2.78 vs $2.84 est, a narrow miss) but the stock rallied 4.51% on constructive guidance and domestic pricing strength. The tariff structure that was established before the war provides a demand floor for US steel producers independent of the geopolitical cycle. CAT, STLD, and PCAR all benefit from the reshoring and infrastructure spending themes that IOWN's thesis emphasizes. **The physical world matters.**

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